PYTHON FOR HEALTHCARE · STANFORD TECHNOLOGY TRAINING

Before You Start: Setup Guide

Sessions: Monday, Oct 26, and Wednesday, Oct 28, 2026 · 9:00 am to 12:00 pm Pacific · Live on Zoom

Nothing to install. We'll work in **Google Colab**, which runs Python notebooks in your web browser. Google's AI assistant, **Gemini**, is built in. No Python experience is needed.

What you need

- A computer with Google Chrome (recommended), Edge, or Firefox.
- A **personal Google account**, such as a Gmail address. It's free.
- Zoom. A second screen helps: Zoom on one, Colab on the other. Otherwise, place the two windows side by side.
- About 5 minutes before Monday to run the setup check below.

Run the setup check (5 minutes)

1. Open the setup check in your browser:

```
colab.research.google.com/github/lmlevine/python-for-healthcare/blob/main/notebooks/
00_setup_check.ipynb
```

2. If you see **Sign in** at the top right, sign in with your personal Google account.
3. Click **File → Save a copy in Drive**. Work in the copy that opens (its title starts with "Copy of").
4. Click inside the gray code cell and press **Shift + Enter**. The first run takes 10 to 30 seconds. If Colab warns that the notebook wasn't authored by Google, click **Run anyway**.
5. When you see ✅ **Python and the course data are working**, you're set.
6. Open the **Gemini** panel (✦ in Colab's toolbar) and type: *Explain what the code cell above does, in two sentences.* If Gemini answers, you're done.

> **Why a personal Google account?**
> Work and school accounts sometimes have Colab's AI features switched off by an administrator. A personal account gives everyone the same tools. You won't upload anything: the course data load automatically.

If something goes wrong

What you see	What to do
An error that mentions "HTTP Error 404"	The course files aren't at that address yet, or the link changed. Tell the instructor.
Any other error while reading the CSV	Wait a minute, then run the cell again.
"Runtime disconnected"	Click **Reconnect** (top right), then run the cell again. Colab disconnects idle notebooks.

What you see	What to do
Nothing happens when you press Shift + Enter	Click inside the cell first, so your cursor is in it.
No Gemini button, or "not available"	Check that you're signed in with a personal Google account. If it still doesn't appear, come anyway: every lab step that uses Gemini has a fallback.
The page is slow or won't load	Use Chrome, close other heavy tabs, and reload.

> **One rule for this course: synthetic data only**
> Every dataset in the course is synthetic. Never put real patient data into Colab or Gemini on a personal account, including data that's been de-identified. Session 1 covers where real data can go at Stanford.

During class

- Links to each notebook will be posted in the Zoom chat. All course notebooks are also at **github.com/lmlevine/python-for-healthcare**.
- Each notebook opens read-only. Use **File → Save a copy in Drive** before you start working.
- Questions before Monday? Reply to the email this guide came with.